CHAPTER 4

# CULTURE AND SOCIALISATION

**CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:**
Master the sociological concept of culture, its cognitive, normative, and material dimensions, ethnocentrism versus cultural relativism, the multifaceted process of socialization across the life course, and the primary and secondary agencies of socialization including family, peer groups, schools, mass media, and workplace.

## 4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Tripartite Dimensions of Culture:** Culture is the learned and shared design for living in a society; structured into: (a) cognitive dimension (knowledge, ideas, empirical beliefs about physical and social worlds), (b) normative dimension (values, folkways, mores, statutory laws guiding acceptable conduct), and (c) material dimension (concrete tools, artifacts, buildings, technologies produced by human labor).

• **Ethnocentrism versus Cultural Relativism:** Ethnocentrism is the uncritical habit of judging other cultures using one's own cultural values as the standard of superiority; cultural relativism posits that every cultural practice, belief, and ritual must be understood within the context of its own societal values and historical meanings.

• **The Socialization Process:** Socialization is the lifelong process of social interaction through which individuals internalize societal norms, acquire languages, construct self-identity, and learn social roles; divided into primary socialization (early childhood in family, intense emotional bonding) and secondary socialization (schooling, peer groups, workplace, media across youth and adulthood).

• **Agencies of Socialization:** Family provides the earliest foundations of language, moral values, and gender roles; peer groups foster egalitarian cooperation and peer solidarity outside adult supervision; schools instill formal academic curricula alongside hidden curricula of discipline and competition; mass media shapes aspirations, role models, and consumer sensibilities.

## ESSENTIAL SOCIOLOGICAL CONCEPTS & INSTITUTIONS

$$\text{Culture} \iff \text{Cognitive (Knowledge)} + \text{Normative (Values and Laws)} + \text{Material (Artifacts)}$$

*Tripartite Dimensional Architecture of Culture*

$$\text{Lifelong Socialization} \rightarrow \{\text{Primary (Family, Early Emotional Core)}, \quad \text{Secondary (School, Media, Peer Groups)}\}$$

*Developmental Phases of Social Conditioning*

$$\text{Cultural Evaluation} \iff \text{Ethnocentrism (Own Culture as Superior)} \neq \text{Cultural Relativism (Contextual Meaning)}$$

*Paradigmatic Contrast in Cross-Cultural Analysis*

$$\text{Normative Continuum} \iff \text{Folkways (Customs)} \rightarrow \text{Mores (Moral Imperatives)} \rightarrow \text{Statutory Laws (Codified Penalties)}$$

*Hierarchy of Normative Stringency and Sanctions*

## CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Culture is entirely acquired and learned through social communication and symbolic interaction; it is never genetically inherited or biologically transmitted through DNA or race.

• **Alert:** Cultural relativism is an objective analytical posture necessary to avoid ethnocentric bias in social research; it does not require ethical condonation of severe human rights violations.

• **Alert:** The 'hidden curriculum' in schools operates implicitly alongside the formal syllabus, instilling deference to authority, punctuality, and competitive individualism.

## HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

### 1. Define culture from a sociological perspective. [Score: 2 Marks]

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Sociological Definition:** Culture is the learned, shared, and symbolically transmitted way of life of a society, encompassing beliefs, customs, values, laws, knowledge, and material artifacts. **[1 Mark]**

• **Distinctive Feature:** It is not biologically transmitted through genetic inheritance, but acquired by individuals through continuous socialization. **[1 Mark]**

### 2. Differentiate between primary socialization and secondary socialization. [Score: 2 Marks]

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Primary Socialization:** Takes place during infancy and early childhood within the family; it involves profound emotional attachments and forms the foundational core of personality and language. **[1 Mark]**

• **Secondary Socialization:** Occurs in later childhood, adolescence, and adulthood across institutions like schools, peer groups, workplace, and media, teaching specialized skills and social roles. **[1 Mark]**

### 3. Explain the three dimensions of culture (cognitive, normative, and material) with an example for each. [Score: 3 Marks]

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **1. Cognitive Dimension:** Refers to how we process knowledge and understand the world around us (e.g. scientific understanding of medicine, literacy, mathematical calculations). **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Normative Dimension:** Rules of conduct, moral values, folkways, and legal codes that guide how individuals should act in society (e.g. greeting elders with respect, following traffic laws). **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Material Dimension:** The tangible, physical artifacts and tools created by humans to modify their environment (e.g. smartphones, clothing, bridges, computers). **[1 Mark]**

### 4. Distinguish between ethnocentrism and cultural relativism. Why is ethnocentrism problematic in pluralist societies? [Score: 4 Marks]

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Ethnocentrism:** The tendency to apply one's own cultural values as the universal standard of judging other cultures, regarding one's own customs as superior and others as backward or uncivilized. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Cultural Relativism:** The methodological principle that a cultural practice or belief can only be accurately understood and evaluated within its own social and historical context, rather than through foreign benchmarks. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Problems of Ethnocentrism:** In diverse pluralist societies, ethnocentrism generates communal intolerance, ethnic chauvinism, xenophobia, and violent friction between different linguistic and religious communities. **[1 Mark]**

### 5. Explain how peer groups act as an agent of socialization and contrast their influence with that of the family. [Score: 4 Marks]

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Peer Group Socialization:** Peer groups are primary groups composed of individuals of approximately the same age and social status; interaction is egalitarian, horizontal, and voluntary, allowing children to learn negotiation, compromise, and autonomy away from adult surveillance. **[2 Marks]**

• **Contrast with Family:** In the family, authority is hierarchical and adult-dominated, emphasizing obedience to parents and tradition; peer groups provide an egalitarian platform where young people can explore alternative identities, subcultural styles, and peer solidarity. **[2 Marks]**

**6. What is the 'hidden curriculum' in schools? How does it socialize children into societal norms and hierarchies? [Score: 5 Marks]**

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Concept of Hidden Curriculum:** The unwritten, unstated, and informal lessons, values, and perspectives that students learn at school in addition to the formal academic syllabus. **[2 Marks]**

• **Socialization into Punctuality and Order:** Through school bells, timetables, and assembly line queues, students are conditioned to internalize mechanical punctuality, time discipline, and deference to institutional authority. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Preparation for Competitive Capitalist Workplace:** The grading system and competitive sports train students to view peers as competitors, conditioning them to accept meritocratic grading and unequal hierarchies in the adult capitalist economy. **[1.5 Marks]**

**7. Mass media has become one of the most powerful agencies of socialization in contemporary society. Critically evaluate this statement, pointing out both constructive and distorting impacts. [Score: 6 Marks]**

**Answer & Key Valuation Steps:**

• **Mass Media as Socializing Agent:** Television, newspapers, internet, social media networks, and streaming platforms reach vast populations continuously, transmitting values, cultural role models, and global information directly into households. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Constructive Impacts:** Expands cognitive horizons, fosters awareness of democratic rights, promotes social justice causes, facilitates distance learning, and bridges regional cultural divides by exposing audiences to diverse perspectives. **[2 Marks]**

• **Distorting and Negative Impacts:** Promotes aggressive consumerism and commercialism, normalizes violent behaviors, creates unrealistic body image anxieties among youth, disseminates unchecked disinformation or fake news, and reinforces communal stereotypes through sensationalized prime time broadcasting. **[2.5 Marks]**